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Aurangzeb as Iconoclast? Vaishnava Accounts of the Krishna images' Exodus from Braj*



HEIDI PAUWELS AND EMILIA BACHRACH

Abstract

This paper studies how Brajbhāṣā Vaishnava narratives describe the role the Mughal emperor Aurangzeb played in the displacement of Krishna images from the Braj heartland in the 1660s and 1670s. While contemporary discourse frequently suggests that the emperor was a villain persecuting beloved Hindu deities, who in turn are victims forcibly moved from their original homeland, the early-modern vernacular narratives we consider here perceive these peregrinations in rather more complex ways. This article foregrounds the case of the best-known dispersed Krishna image: Śrī Nāthajī, a deity of the Vallabha-Sampradāya, now residing in the Mewar area of Rajasthan. It analyses mostly the discourse of the Śrī Nāthajī kī Prākāṣya-Vārtā, or 'The story of the Appearance of Śrī Nāthajī', attributed to Vallabha's descendant, Hariṛāy. The sectarian logic presents Aurangzeb as an ardent, if uncouth, devotee and Śrī Nāthajī as an autonomous agent, not a victim, but rather a victor.

It is often uncritically repeated that the iconoclasm of the Mughal emperor Aurangzeb (r. 1658–1707) caused the displacement and dispersal of Krishna images from the Braj heartland around the late 1660s and early 1670s. This narrative casts the emperor in the role of a villain persecuting beloved Hindu images, and the images as victims forcibly moved from their original homeland in a grand-scale exodus. But is that how these peregrinations were perceived at the time?

This article foregrounds vernacular sources that represent these events from the perspective of the caretakers of the images, in order to allow for a hearing of a broader range of voices. As it turns out, analysis of the tropes and topoi used in the Vaishnava stories complicates the black and white picture of persecution and victimisation that has become conventional.

*This paper was first presented in 2012 by Heidi Pauwels at a workshop at Columbia University, NY, organised by Sudipta Kaviraj. Many thanks are due to him and all those who offered insightful comments at the oral presentation, in particular Jack Hawley of Barnard College and Samira Sheikh of Vanderbilt, who after the presentation put Heidi on track of Emilia Bachrach's as yet unpublished work on the same *Vārtā* text. This led to a very fruitful collaboration on sorting out the manuscript situation of the text.

†The original version of this article was published with an error in the author's email address on the last page. A Corrigendum detailing this has been published and the error rectified in the online and print PDF and HTML copies.

Instead it reveals multiple motives and agents behind the displacement of the Braj images. This is not to deny that there were conflicts over religious sites and images in the course of India's history, and that those affected by these actions registered such destruction.¹ What we present here, however, demonstrates that responses to the figure of Aurangzeb and his 'iconoclasm' in Braj were more nuanced than is commonly portrayed in narratives that focus on essentialised Hindu-Muslim confrontation.² The bulk of the article presents a case study of the narratives regarding one of the best-known dispersed Krishna images: Śrī Nāthajī, a deity of the Vallabha-Sampradāya now residing in the Mewar area of Rajasthan, in a town named after it, Nathdwara. This image is the one that immediately comes to the modern mind when speaking of the 'exodus' of Braj images and therefore, provides a fitting place to begin our investigation.³

The assertion is often made that Śrī Nāthajī left in response to Aurangzeb's iconoclastic campaign.⁴ In particular, the deity's departure is understood to be a reaction to Aurangzeb's destruction of a temple in Mathura and his building of a mosque at its site. While this temple is now understood to be Krishna's birthplace, there is no evidence that at the time it was seen in that way. All sources simply refer to it as Keśavarāya.⁵ The perception that the destruction of this temple was due to iconoclasm is an oversimplification; there were complex motivations prompting its demolition. At the time, there was a Jat uprising in the region, right on the highway from Delhi to Agra, during which Abd un-Nabi, the *fauzdar* of Mathura, was murdered in May 1669. The temple's destruction was part of Aurangzeb's retaliation, which took place in January 1670. The severity of Aurangzeb's reaction was compounded by the role that Mathura Brahmins had played in the escape of Shivaji and his son from Mughal captivity in Agra in 1666, as well as the former patronage of the temple by Aurangzeb's rival for the throne, his brother Dara Shikoh.⁶ Finally, traditional accounts date Śrī Nāthajī's departure from Braj as occurring in October 1669.⁷ Since this date is before

¹For an instance of a Jaina and a Sanskrit *Mahātmya*'s response to desecration of their respective images in Sultanate times, see Ph. Granoff, "Tales of Broken Limbs and Bleeding Wounds: Responses to Muslim Iconoclasm in Medieval India", *East and West*, 41.1/4 (1991), pp. 189–203. For a nuanced view of reactions to the Somnath desecration by Mahmud of Ghaznah, see R. Thapar, *Somanatha: The Many Voices of a History* (London, 2005).

²Documentary evidence has shown that under Aurangzeb, but for a short moment of panic, it was very much 'business as usual' in the Braj area, see I. Habib, "Dealing with multiplicity: Mughal administration in Braj Bhumi under Aurangzeb (1659–1707)", *Studies in People's History*, 3.2 (1996), pp. 151–164.

³This article focuses on Hindu discourses only. The complexity of the discourses of iconoclasm in the Islamic world is a different topic that has already begun to be unpacked. Romila Thapar has very lucidly published on this with regard to Mahmud of Ghaznah. See her *Somanatha*, pp. 36–72. Finbarr Flood, covering a broader swath of the Sultanate period, analyses this in terms of its polemicist tropes, political discourse of conquest and ritual subordination, multi-stage peregrinations and redistribution of objects in asymmetric exchanges, economic discourse of circulation of precious metals, and the spectacle entailed in the reception of the icons on display; see his *Objects of Translation: Material Culture and Medieval "Hindu-Muslim" Encounter* (Princeton, 2009), pp. 26–37. Flood argues for understanding the phenomenon as an intricate interplay of religious, economic and political factors. As we will see, something similar is going on in Hindu discourses.

⁴A representative example is a glossary definition of Śrī Nāthajī in R. Snell, *The Hindi Classical Tradition: A Braj Bhāṣā Reader* (London, 1994), p. 194.

⁵Research showing this is summarised in H. Pauwels, "A Tale of Two Temples: Mathurā's Keśavadeva and Orchhā's Caturbhujadeva", *South Asian History and Culture*, 2.2 (March 2011), pp. 279–280.

⁶*Ibid.*, pp. 288–290.

⁷1726 VS, Āśvin *sudi* 15, on a Friday according to Ā. G. Harirāy (ed.), *Śrīnāthjī kī prākṛtya-Vārtā* [Go. Śrī Harirāy mahānubhāv kṛt] (Nathdwara, 1968), p. 52.

the destruction of the Mathura temple, the move cannot have been a direct response to iconoclasm. It would be more precise to conclude that the image was removed because of the Jat uprising and the expectation that reprisals would be forthcoming — in short, by the economic and political unrest in the area.

Such historical circumstances must bear on our understanding of Śrī Nāthajī's move, but this is not our focus here. Instead, we analyse the discourses that explained Śrī Nāthajī's move — that is, how the sect itself has understood the deity's relocation. To explore sectarian views on Śrī Nāthajī's peregrinations, we present an analysis of the *Śrī Nāthajī kī Prākṛṭya-Vārtā*, or 'The story of the Appearance of Śrī Nāthajī' (ŚNPI).⁸ This *Vārtā* is (like the other *Vārtā* literature of the sect) attributed to Harirāy. If this attribution holds true, it would be an eyewitness account of these events, since Harirāy lived in the seventeenth century, and probably compiled his *Vārtā* works towards the end of his life (Harirāy's traditional dates are 1590–1715).⁹ He was a great-grandson of Vallabha's son Viṭṭhalnāth (Harirāy's father was Kalyāṇrāy, who was the eldest son of Govindrāy, Viṭṭhalnāth's second son). Harirāy was originally from Gokul, but he seems to have travelled to Gujarat and to Rajasthan, where shrines commemorating his presence are still prevalent. Notably he spent time in the village later named Nathdwara, where Śrī Nāthajī was eventually installed, and in the adjacent village Khimnaur in Mewar, where his memorial (*baiṭhak*) marks his visitation.¹⁰ Thus, if Harirāy is the author of the *Śrī Nāthajī kī Prākṛṭya-Vārtā*, he would have been writing about Śrī Nāthajī's travels from a contemporaneous vantage point, and close to the place where the deity finally came to be located.¹¹ In addition to the *Śrī Nāthajī kī prākṛṭya-Vārtā*, we will also refer to other sectarian literature and to non-sectarian sources, including official documents, Persian Mughal and non-official chronicles and Sanskrit court poetry. However, the focus will first be on analysing the sectarian logic of the vernacular narrative that presents itself from the point of view of the image's caretakers.

To contextualise the Vallabhan account of Śrī Nāthajī, we will also present a number of other perspectives, including an account produced by a different sect, the Caitanya-Sampradāya, on Śrī Nāthajī's early movements in the sixteenth century. Then we will discuss peregrinations by other Vallabhan deities that occurred during the same period as Śrī Nāthajī's move: the images of the third *gaddī* Śrī Dvārakādhīśajī (now in Kankroli, Rajasthan) and Śrī Bālakṛṣṇajī (now in Surat, Gujarat). Finally, we will consider a now less-known Krishna image in Kishangarh, Rajasthan, one of the earliest to have been moved from Braj, even before Aurangzeb became emperor in 1658.

⁸*Ibidem*. The text is also known as *Śrī Govardhananāthajī kī Prākṛṭya-Vārtā*, and other variants of that name, see fn. on manuscripts below. See also F. Smith, "Dark Matter in Vārtāland: On the Enterprise of History in Early Puṣṭimārga Discourse", *Journal of Hindu Studies* 2 (2009), pp. 27–47.

⁹R. S. McGregor, *Hindi Literature from its Beginnings to the Nineteenth Century* (Wiesbaden, 1984), pp. 209–210.

¹⁰R. G. Shah, *Vallabha Cult and Śrī Harirāyājī: Contributions of Śrī Harirāyājī to Vallabha School* (Delhi, 2005), pp. 77–88 and plate 9; V. V. Caturvedī, *Gosvāmī Harirāyājī aur unkā Brajbhāṣā Sāhitya* (Mathura, 1976), pp. 49–50, 65–66; P. D. Mital, *Gosvāmī Harirāyājī kī Pad-sāhitya* (Mathura, 1962), p. 7.

¹¹He may have been instrumental in establishing the Mewar king's interest in Śrī Nāthajī, and there is a picture of Raj Singh visiting him preserved in the temple of Viṭṭhalanāthajī in Nathdwara (Shah, *Vallabha Cult*, p. 82 and plate 11).

Śrī Nāthajī in the Vallabhan sectarian accounts

Śrī Nāthajī and the Vallabha-Sampradāya

The image of Śrī Nāthajī is believed to have been established originally on Mount Govardhana in Braj for formal Vaishnava worship by the Sanskrit theologian Vallabhācārya (1478–1530).¹² Vallabha's son Viṭṭhalnāth (1516–86) expanded the *sampradāya* founded by his father and elaborated the practices of *sevā* (loving worship) for Śrī Nāthajī, who is understood by his caretakers to be a *svarūpa* or full manifestation of the divine. The round-the-clock *sevā* of Śrī Nāthajī is characterised by elaborate rituals (of feeding, dressing and singing to the deity) that occur during eight prescribed periods (*aṣṭayāma*) of the day and change seasonally according to a cycle of sectarian festivals through the year.¹³ Viṭṭhalnāth was influential enough to secure *farmāns* from the Mughal rulers.¹⁴ It seems that only under his tenure did the sect gain exclusive control over the shrine of Śrī Nāthajī at Govardhana by expelling the Bengali Vaishnavas that had been initially involved in the deity's worship.¹⁵ Śrī Nāthajī is one of nine deities (*navanidhi*) that are very prestigious in the sect, most of which are of smaller size than Śrī Nāthajī (approximately 4.5 ft. in height). All of the *navanidhi* are believed to have once been cared for by Vallabha or his early disciples. After the death of Viṭṭhalnāth, each of his eight sons (seven natural and one adopted) inherited the right of initiation into the sect and it still exclusively rests with their descendants, called Maharajas. Viṭṭhalnāth's sons inherited the worship of one or more of these nine images, around which they established eight *gaddīs* — that is, thrones or houses of sectarian authority.¹⁶ Śrī Nāthajī, the primary deity, went to Viṭṭhalnāth's eldest son, whose descendants have held it in their control ever since. As this particular lineage presides in Nathdwara and cares for Śrī Nāthajī, it is considered to be foremost, and its eldest living male descendant is called *tilakāyat*.¹⁷ In addition to Śrī Nāthajī, we will also be concerned here with two other *navanidhi* images: those of Śrī Dvārkaadhīśajī and Śrī Bālakṣṇajī, granted by Viṭṭhalnāth to his third and sixth son respectively. By the seventeenth century, however, both had ended up in the custody of the third house.¹⁸

¹²See Ch. Vaudeville, "The Govardhan Myth in North India", *Indo-Iranian Journal*, 22.1 (1980), pp. 24–26.

¹³See A. Ambalal, *Krishna as Shrinathji: Rajasthani Paintings from Nathdwara* (Ahmedabad, 1987); see also M. Horstmann and A. Mishra, "Vaishnava Sampradāyas on the Importance of Ritual: A Comparison of the Two Contemporaneous Approaches by Viṭṭhalnātha and Jīva Gosvāmī", in *Bhakti Beyond the Forest: Current Research of Early Modern Literatures in North India, 2003–2009*, (ed.) Imre Bangha (New Delhi, 2012), pp. 155–176; and P. Bennett, "Krishna's Own Form: Image Worship in the Pushti Marga", *Journal of Vaishnava Studies*, 1.4 (1993), pp. 109–134.

¹⁴See K. M. Jhaveri, *Imperial Farmans, A.D. 1577 to A.D. 1805, granted to the ancestors of His Holiness The Tilakayat Maharaj* (Bombay, 1928). Even though some of the grants seem to be forgeries (T. Mukherjee and I. Habib, "Akbar and the Temples of Mathura and Environs", *Proceedings of the Indian History Congress*, 48 (1988), pp. 238, 248–249), there still are several apparently authentic documents that support the point. We thank J. S. Hawley of Barnard College for bringing this to our attention.

¹⁵Vaudeville, "The Govardhan Myth", pp. 39, 43 n. 10, p. 44 n. 18–19 and pp. 44–45 n. 21; R. K. Barz, *The Bhakti sect of Vallabhācārya* (New Delhi, 1976), pp. 216–233.

¹⁶For a handy overview chart, see Barz, *Bhakti sect*, p. 55 and N. Peabody, *Hindu Kingship and Polity in Precolonial India* (Cambridge, 1991), plate 3.

¹⁷The issues involved in inheritance are actually quite complex, and the story is not one of straightforward primogeniture. Some sense of this is to follow, but the issue is too complex to explore in detail here.

¹⁸S. Saha, "The Movement of *Bhakti* along a North-West Axis: Tracing the History of the Puṣṭimārg between the Sixteenth and Nineteenth Centuries", *International Journal of Hindu Studies*, 11.3 (2004), pp. 138–139.

Śrī Nāthajī kī Prākṛṭya-Vārtā

Stories about Vallabha and Viṭṭhalnāth's disciples initially circulated orally and came to be written down in the seventeenth century. This *Vārtā* or 'story' literature in Braj prose gives a vivid picture of the sect's recruitment and its leaders' preaching practices.¹⁹ Many *Vārtā* texts are also devotional and didactic in character, and are consequently used by devotees (both pre-modern and modern) as guides to sectarian theology, ritual and social practice.²⁰ The final redaction of these stories is ascribed to the aforementioned prolific Harirāy, who was Viṭṭhalnāth's great-grandson, and was initiated into the *sampradāya* by his illustrious great-uncle Gokulnāth of the fourth *gaddī*. One of these *Vārtā* texts is the *Śrī Nāthajī kī Prākṛṭya-Vārtā*, which elaborates how the image of Śrī Nāthajī was first discovered and worshiped at Mount Govardhana.²¹ The narrative continues by describing what happened to Śrī Nāthajī subsequently, including the deity's journey to its current site in Rajasthan. This is the part of the *Vārtā* that is of interest to us here as it reveals sectarian understandings of why the image left its original location. It also features an interesting shift within the text's portrayal of the Mughal emperor, for whereas in the early part of the *Vārtā* the emperor is portrayed as protector of the *sampradāya* who settles its domestic conflicts,²² in later layers of the text he takes on a different role, as we shall examine in this article.

Is this text really an eye-witness account? At the outset, we should reflect on the status of the text that is available to us. First, the attribution to Harirāy may well be doubted, as he figures in the *sampradāya* as a sort of Vyāsa for the Purāṇa tradition: by default texts are ascribed to him. It has been suggested that the tone of the work differs from the seriousness of the *Bhāva-prakāśa* ("Illumination of the Meaning") interventions in other *Vārtā* literature that have, with somewhat more certainty, also been ascribed to Harirāy.²³ On the other hand, the more playful and folksy tone of the *Śrī Nāthajī kī Prākṛṭya-Vārtā* accords more closely with that found in the *Caurāsī* and *Do Sau Bāvan Vāiṣṇavan kī Vārtā*, the two primary texts of the *Vārtā* genre.²⁴ Like these better-known *Vārtā* texts, the *Śrī Nāthajī kī Prākṛṭya-Vārtā* is

¹⁹R. K. Barz, "Vallabha Sampradāya", in *Brill's Encyclopedia of Hinduism*, (eds.) K. A. Jacobsen, H. Basu, A. Malinar, V. Naryanan (Leiden, 2009), Vol. 1, p. 613; V. Dalmia, "The 'Other' in the World of the Faithful", in *Bhakti in Current Research, 2001-2003: Proceedings of the Ninth International Conference on Early Devotional Literature in New Indo-Aryan Languages, Heidelberg, 23-26 July 2003*, (ed.) Monika Horstmann (Delhi, 2006), pp. 115-138.

²⁰See E. Bachrach, "Reading the Medieval in the Modern: The Living Tradition of Hagiography in the Vallabh Sect of Contemporary Gujarat", PhD. diss. (The University of Texas at Austin, 2014).

²¹There is a translation of the first part in Vaudeville, "The Govardhan Myth", pp. 18-27 and a paraphrase (with some significant omissions) of the whole text by T. Shyamdas, *The Amazing Story of Shri Nathji*, (Vrindaban, 2004).

²²E.g., in the first half of the seventeenth century under the sectarian leadership of Viṭṭhalrāy (*ŚNPIV* 65, pp. 44-45).

²³J. S. Hawley, personal communication with Pauwels, 29 September 2012. Contemporary scholars of the tradition have also noted the inconsistency of writing ascribed to Harirāy (in both Braj and Sanskrit) — not only in narrative style, but also in the presentation and analysis of basic theological principles (Shyam Manohar Goswami, personal communication with Bachrach, 15 June 2012).

²⁴In contrast, it is very different in tone from the heavily Gosvāmī, merchant, and Raja-focused nineteenth-century *Śrī Mukundarājajī kī Vārtā*, described by V. Dalmia, "The Establishment of the Sixth Gaddī of the Vallabha Sampradāy: Narrative Structure and the Use of Authority in a *Vārtā* of the Nineteenth Century", in *Studies in South Asian devotional literature: Research papers 1988-1991, presented at the Fifth Conference on Devotional Literature in New Indo-Aryan Languages, held at Paris, École Française d'Extrême-Orient, 9-12 July 1991*, (eds.) F. Mallison and A. Entwistle (New Delhi, 1994), pp. 94-117. It also feels more broad-based popular than the turn-of-the-nineteenth-century *Śrī Dvārakādīhī kī Prākṛṭya-Vārtā*, ascribed to Brajbhūṣaṇ Mahārāj (1778-1819 or 1835-76 VS), for discussion of which, see below in the second part of the paper.

ultimately attributed to Gokulnāth, Viṭṭhalnāth's fourth son and Harirāy's guru, who is said to have orally related the accounts to Harirāy, who wrote them down.²⁵ This authorship is established in the first line of the text (*ŚNPV* 1). It is remarkable, though, that in contrast to the other *Vārtās*, this text provides many dates. Moreover, the extant printed editions do not specify their source or mention any older manuscripts on which they might be based. So far, no manuscript study of the text has been published.²⁶

There are, however, quite a few manuscripts known to exist, three of which Bachrach was able to examine.²⁷ None of these manuscripts can reliably be dated to before the 1850s.²⁸ This casts some doubt on the attribution to Harirāy and its dating to the seventeenth century.²⁹ There is only one printed edition readily available, which was prepared in 1968 (2025 VS) at the request of Śrī Govindlālī in Nathdwara. This text is the one referred to here as *ŚNPV*.³⁰ It is very close to an older edition printed at Lakshmi Venkateshvar Steam Press in Bombay in 1905.³¹ There is a record of an older lithograph published in 1884 at the request of Munshi Naval Kishore by Kanhaiyālāl Bhārgava, printed at the Mumbai ul-Ulūm

²⁵“The Stories of Eighty-Four Vaishnavas” and “The Stories of Two-Hundred and Fifty-Two Vaishnavas” provide hagiographical accounts for the disciples of Vallabha and Viṭṭhalnāth respectively. It should be noted that several of the episodes that appear in the early part of our text also appear in the *Caurāśī Vaiṣṇavan kī Vārtā*—although none of the episodes that concern us in this article.

²⁶H. N. Taṇḍan in his *Vārtā-Sāhitya* (Aligarh, 1960), p. 107, mentions only editions.

²⁷The first *Śrī Nāthajī kī Nija Prāgatya-Vārtā* examined by Bachrach (90 folios) was originally from a sectarian temple (*havelī*) in Bahadrapur (Bhavnagar District, Gujarat), but is now kept in a private collection in Ahmedabad (anonymous). It contains no colophon or date, but appears to be from the late nineteenth century. The second manuscript (75 folios, badly damaged and incomplete) is dated 1855 CE (1912 VS Caitra *sudī* 13) and is kept in a private temple library in Ahmedabad. Its colophon specifies that it was written for Ācārya Abhirām Mahāśaṅkar by Pārekḥ Māyācand Kuśaldās. The third manuscript, found in the same temple library (106 folios), contains no colophon or date, but may be from the early nineteenth century. All three texts are similar to each other (the varying number of folios is due to inclusion of non-*Vārtā* material) and are very similar to the printed Venkateshvar edition (with some omissions).

²⁸Other manuscripts that we were not able to inspect include the following: Vrindaban Research Institute in its catalogue lists a *Govardhananāthajī kī Prākṛtya-Vārtā* (101 fols.), dated 1825 (1882 VS; but the last folio, presumably the one with the date, is written in a different hand). A search of the electronic database *namami.org* reveals other manuscripts, significantly none of which are attributed to Harirāyji: under the title *Govardhana-Prākṛtyam*, a manuscript (96 folios) preserved at RORI Jodhpur (P.W.D. Road) ms. no. 18019, and one (102 folios) preserved with Śrīmatī Sīmā Gauttam, 27/307 Retvālī in Kotā, ms. no. 1; under the title *Govardhananātha kī Nija Vārtā*, a (143 folio) manuscript in RORI Jaipur (Rāmacandrajī kā mandir) ms. no. 12705/2; under the title *Govardhananāthajī ke Prāgatya ke Prakār*, a manuscript (said to be complete in 49 pages) in Rājasthānī Śodh Sansthān, Caupāsānī, Jodhpur, ms. no. 16497 (3), and one (65 fols) in Shri Sanjay Shamra Research Institute in Jaipur, ms. no. 423/175/1, estimated to be from the twentieth century; under the title *Govardhananāthajī kī Prākṛtya kī Vārtā*, a manuscript (said to be complete in 65 pages) in Rajasthan Oriental Research Institute Jodhpur ms. no. 25457, the scribe is a Vaṃśīdhar Purohit, and in the same collection (said to be complete in 62 folios) ms. no. 20697, written by a Tulārām in Gokul. Finally, it appears that Ambalāl had access to a manuscript (*Krishna as Shrīnathji* p. 175). Unfortunately no dates are provided for any of the *namami* manuscripts. Moreover, without inspecting them in person it is hard to say whether they are of the same text. The variance in number of folios makes one suspect the text as edited (92 pages) has shorter and longer versions in the manuscript material.

²⁹There are examples of contemporary creation of such texts in order to legitimise local worship sites, such as Harirāy, *Śrīgovardhanaprākṛtyam nāma Puṇṣasambhavamahākāvya Mahākavi Harirāyaviracitam* (Jodhpur, 1987). The author of this Sanskrit text with a similar title is confusingly not the same Harirāy who wrote our *Vārtā*, but a contemporary Gosvāmī of the Caupāsānī shrine. In the forewords to this 1987 edition, it is repeatedly stressed that this text proves the respectable origins of the image venerated there. This modern example, where we know a different Harirāy is the author may caution us that there may be conflation at work also in our text.

³⁰Ā. G. Harirāy, *Śrīnāthajī kī Prākṛtya Vārtā* (Nathdwara, 1968).

³¹Mohanlāl Viṣṇulāl Pāṇḍyā, *Śrī Govardhananāthajī ke Prākṛtya kī Vārtā Brajbhāṣā meṃ* [Gosvāmī Śrī Harirāyji Mahārāj kṛt] (Bombay, 1905). Pāṇḍyā mentions the contemporary Maharajas Govardhanlāl and Jivānlāl (p. 3). The dedication is dated 1878 (1935 VS), so presumably it is the 1878 text mentioned separately by Taṇḍan, *Vārtā-Sāhitya*, p. 107.

press in Mathura,³² which in turn was based on an 1868 print of the Vyaghrapad Press at Beswan, owned by Thakur Giriprasād Varmā.³³ In his foreword to the aforementioned 1905 edition, Mohanlāl Viṣṇulāl Pāṇḍyā mentions this older 1868 edition from “Viśvāmitrapur” (Veśmā/Beswan), but specifies that it is full of infelicities (*prastāvanā* 5). He calls his own project a “restoration” (*jīṃoddhār*), which he wants to present to contemporary historians (*itihās lekhaḥ*) and archeologists (*prācīn padārthan ke śodhak*).³⁴ Such comments alert us to the fact that the text of the 1905 edition is a polemical construct. Moreover, Pāṇḍyā says that he received help to research the book from “Śrī Gaṭṭūjī”, also known as Śrī Govardhan Lālājī (*prastāvanā*, 6). This is none else than the Gaṭṭū Lālājī (1844–97) who is famous for formulating a Vallabhan apologia in the face of the double challenge raised in the late nineteenth century by the so-called Maharaja Libel Case in Mumbai and the king Ram Singh II’s (r. 1835–80) persecution of Vaishnavas in Jaipur.³⁵ At the same time, Dayānand Sarasvatī was challenging the practice of image worship, and specifically targeting the Vallabhans as heterodox.³⁶

In the light of this social context, together with the state of extant manuscript history, one has to caution that, while it is attributed to the late seventeenth or early eighteenth century, strictly speaking the text as we have it can be traced only as far back as 1855 — a time rife with troubles for the Vallabha-Sampradāya. The first publication in 1868 also followed a highly polemical 1862 tract deflating Vallabhan claims about Śrī Nāthajī, authored by a former administrative manager of Nathdwara under the pseudonym of Blakaṭānand.³⁷ This document asserts that the deity was originally a Bhairava image that was worshiped by Bengalis, forcibly appropriated by Viṭṭhalnāth, and still worshiped in Tantric fashion.³⁸ In a climate with such suspicions being cast on Śrī Nāthajī himself, it is not surprising that sectarian authors felt the need to publish a straightforward narrative history of the deity’s discovery and trajectory. On top of this, the version of the 1905 text currently available went through an editorial redaction that took place in a nationalist climate, with increasing polarisation between Hindus and Muslims and a reconstitution of Rajasthani identity in response to colonial critique.³⁹ But whatever the history of the *Śrī Nāthajī kī Prākāṣya-Vārtā*, it remains influential today and its narratives continue to be told — even

³²*Ibid.*, p. 107; U. Stark, *An Empire of Books: The Naval Kishore Press and the Diffusion of the Printed Word in Colonial India* (Ranikhet, 2007), p. 395.

³³*Ibid.*, p. 394.

³⁴This is the same author who edited the *Pythvīrāj-Rāso*, as discussed by Cynthia Talbot forthcoming. We are grateful to Cynthia Talbot for alerting us to this (personal communication, 25 July 2014).

³⁵On these issues, see C. Clémentin-Ojha, *Le trident sur le palais: Une cabale anti-vishnouite dans un royaume hindou à l’époque coloniale* (Paris, 1999) and V. Dalmia *The Nationalization of Hindu Traditions: Bhāratendu Hariścandra and Nineteenth-Century Banāres* (Delhi, 1997), pp. 362–366.

³⁶*Ibid.*, pp. 383–384.

³⁷The publication is called *Vallabhakula Chala Kapāṭa Darpana Athavā Vallabhakula kī Kaccā Cīṭṭhā* (“The mirror of lies and treachery of the Vallabhites or the detailed account of the deeds of the Vallabhites”). Ch. Vaudeville, “Multiple Approaches to a Living Hindu Myth: The Lord of the Govardhan Hill”, in *Hinduism Reconsidered*, (eds.) G. Sontheimer and H. Kulke (New Delhi, 1997), p. 220.

³⁸The author even provides a sketch of the image, comparing it with a Jaina Baṭuk Bhairava from the Mathura Museum. In addition to describing Tantric rites (*vāmamārga*), he details the Vallabhakula’s (Vallabha’s descendants) “moral turpitudes”. *Ibid.*, pp. 221–222.

³⁹N. Martin, “Mīrābai in the Academy and the Politics of Identity”, in *Faces of the Feminine in Ancient, Medieval, and Modern India*, (ed.) Mandakranta Bose (New York, 2000), pp. 162–182.

theatrically performed — in various settings.⁴⁰ Frequently such performances are held in local sectarian temples during the festival that commemorates Śrī Nāthajī's emergence (*Śrī Nāthajī kī Prākāṭya-Utsav*). Often brief vignettes are acted out by children or teens, while a summary of the narrative is read aloud by a narrator using a microphone. As with theatrical renditions of other *Vārtā* narratives, they are characterised by a mixture of reverence and humour. Discourses about and references to this *Vārtā*, and in particular to the role of Aurangzeb, also continue to be commonplace in the sectarian community.

Legitimation of Śrī Nāthajī's Move

Pre-history in flashback

With these qualifications and cautionary remarks in mind, let us look at how the move of Śrī Nāthajī to Mewar is set up in this *Vārtā* text as we have it. After elaborately describing Śrī Nāthajī's worship in Braj from its beginnings (1409, according to most versions of the text) to the mid-seventeenth century, the story proceeds to Śrī Nāthajī's departure from Braj. At precisely this point, a flashback to the time of Viṭṭhalnāth is inserted. During one of his travels, Viṭṭhalnāth is said to have stopped by in “*Sinhāmṇḍ*”, the original name of the village that later became Nathdwara:

At one time, Śrī Gusāṁjī (that is, Viṭṭhalnāth) had gone to Dwarka, where he went by way of Mewar. So there he saw a place named *Sinhāmṇḍ*, which was very beautiful and Gusāṁjī proclaimed to Bābā Harivaṁṣī: “At that spot at a later time Śrī Nāthajī will hold court”. (*ŚNPIV* 69, p. 47)

This story is not told in its chronological order, but as a prophesy in flashback at the point just before Śrī Nāthajī's journey starts, long after the account of Viṭṭhalnāth's life is finished. This follows hagiographical conventions where elements as dreams and flashbacks are used to make sense of the narrative. The story continues to develop the reason why Śrī Nāthajī was attracted to Mewar:

After Śrī Gusāṁjī had camped there for two days, Rana Udai Singhī came for *darśana*. He offered a coin and a village as a gift. Then Śrī Gusāṁjī reciprocated with *prasāda* [sacred food leftovers] and rich clothing, which the king accepted and he prostrated fully before going back home. After that, his queens came for *darśana*. Among [the queens] was the main one Mīrābāī, the Rani's daughter. She too came for *darśana* as did the queen of the prince Ajab Kumvar who took initiation [*brahmasambandha*] from Śrī Gusāṁjī and saw in Śrī Gusāṁjī God's own image [got *svarūpāsakti* of Śrī Gusāṁjī]. And whenever Śrī Gusāṁjī expressed the wish to move on to Dwarka, she would swoon. So Śrī Gusāṁjī commented: “I won't be able to stay here, but Śrījī will give her daily his *darśana*”. With such words, he went on to Dwarka. (*ŚNPIV* 69, pp. 47–48)

Thus, according to the text as we have it, the deity's main reason for leaving for Mewar had to do with a disciple of Viṭṭhalnāth, a princess of Mewar whose ardent devotion was too

⁴⁰ Bachrach witnessed theatrical performances of narratives from the *Śrī Nāthajī kī Prākāṭya-Vārtā* in Ahmedabad city between 2009 and 2012. These performances were in Gujarati, with the occasional citation of a Braj line from printed versions of the Braj text. This article will note some of the scenes that Bachrach witnessed in performance.

much for Viṭṭhalnāth to cope with, but to which Śrī Nāthajī responds by himself coming to visit her in Mewar. Interestingly, the well-known princess Mīrābāī is mentioned.⁴¹ However it is not she but rather the lesser-known Ajab Kuṃvarī who becomes the heroine in the story:

After that, Śrījī would come daily from Girirāj to Mewar to give Ajab Kuṃvarī *darśana* and play board games [*caupar*] with her, after which he would return to Girirāj. One day, Ajab Kuṃvarī begged Śrījī: “You take a lot of trouble coming and going. So you should stay in Mewar and give me daily *darśana*”. Then Śrījī proclaimed such: “As long as Śrī Gusāinājī is present on this earth, I will not go anywhere leaving Girirāj, but afterwards I will surely come to Mewar and will stay here for many years. Then, when Śrī Gusāinājī will again appear in his family and live in Braj, I will go to Braj and will play again for many years on Girirāj”. Proclaiming thus, Śrī Nāthajī returned to Girirāj. (ŚNPV 70, p. 48)⁴²

Hence, a second prophesy is introduced, this one by Śrī Nāthajī himself. While he has been coming to Rajasthan for daily visits, he finally promises Ajab Kuṃvarī that he will come and settle long-term there once Viṭṭhalnāth has passed away. We could consider this flashback story as spurious, but the text as a whole contains many such stories, and so its use does not mark this section uniquely. A prediction about Śrī Nāthajī's departure from the temple in Braj is already made by Vallabha in a much earlier section.⁴³ Such stories are rather to be seen as part and parcel of the hagiographical process, and are well-documented elsewhere.⁴⁴

What we can conclude is that the text carefully frames Śrī Nāthajī's movement as having been predicted by the sectarian authority of Vallabha and Viṭṭhalnāth, on the one hand, and, on the other, as a response to the strong desires of a favourite female *bhakta* — as God gracefully obliging his devotee. With this double move, the *Vārtā*'s author nicely explains the purpose of Śrī Nāthajī's journey: he is making the rounds to oblige his devotees.

The Mleccha-bhakta

However, even for God it is not so easy to make the move from Mount Govardhana to Rajasthan. Since Vallabha himself had firmly installed the deity at the Govardhana shrine, Śrī Nāthajī realises that no one in Vallabha's lineage will let him move: he has to appear to have been forced (*balātkār*) to do so. Thus, Śrī Nāthajī decides to implant the idea in the head of a demon (*asura*). The incident, related below, again a flashback, is presented as happening during Vallabha's lifetime:

When the evening *ārati* was finished, after all servants had gone home, a *mleccha* [barbarian] would come. With his beard he would sweep the holy altar area [*jagamohana*] and the lotus arena [*kamala cauka*]. For twelve years he swept the temple with his beard, but no one got wind of it. By the power of yoga he came through the sky and left the same way. One day, Śrī Govardhananāthajī was happy with him, and took out of his box two betel leaves as *prasāda*, and gave them to him

⁴¹Mīrābāī is mentioned in the other *Vārtā*s, but not in a positive light, see especially the *Vārtā* of Krishnadās Adhikārī (*prasānga* 1, translated in Barz, *Bhakti Sect*), pp. 213–214.

⁴²This is one of the episodes that Bachrach witnessed in youth performance in Ahmedabad city.

⁴³ŚNPV 25, p. 21; Vaudeville, “The Govardhan Myth”, p. 38.

⁴⁴W. L. Smith, *Patterns in North Indian Hagiography* (Stockholm, 2000), pp. 111–113.

with the command: “In fifty-two years, I will have given you the empire and you should have me move from Śrī Girirāja. But from today, you should not visit my temple again. My temple will disappear in the mountain, and you should build a mosque and prostrate. From now on you should not enter anymore”. Upon hearing this command, the Yavana went to Agra and by the wish of Śrījī, he ruled forcefully. (ŚNPV 71, p. 49)⁴⁵

The image of the *mleccha* wiping the floor with his beard uses an ethnic stereotype for comical, belittling effect. Yet this unlikely devotee is clearly dedicated, and even has yogic magical powers. There is also something ambiguous about Śrī Nāthajī’s response: while he is pleased with this devotional service and grants the *mleccha* a reward, he also forbids him to return to the temple. This incident, in short, is permeated with ambiguity.

Who might this mysterious *mleccha* be? The footnote in the modern text (also in the 1905 edition) confirms our suspicion: it was none else than Aurangzeb. While the text continues to talk anonymously about the *mleccha*, used interchangeable with *yavana* (foreigner) or *asura* (demon), and at points *desādhipati* (overlord) or *pātsāh* (emperor) — as it does also elsewhere about other kings — we are prompted by the editor each time to fill in the name of Aurangzeb. Yet the text itself does not make any such specific reference. We are accordingly being asked by the editor to reinterpret this sectarian account with reference to the modern villain of nationalist historiography, Aurangzeb. Still, remarkably, Aurangzeb is not portrayed in a negative light, but rather as a secret ardent devotee, much like Rāvaṇa in devotional *Rāmāyaṇas* is portrayed as secretly a Rāma-*bhakta*.⁴⁶

After this incident, the action is fast-forwarded to the year 1669, when we are informed that the *ṭikait* (*ṭilakāyat*) is now Giridhārjī’s minor son Śrī Dāūjī. Since he was only fifteen years old, his uncle, (also named) Govindjī, took the lead. It is he who answers the door, so to speak, when an imperial messenger arrives with the message:

“Order the *fakirs* of Śrī Gokul to show some miracles. If not, they should be expelled from my country”. Govindjī spoke to Śrījī: “The messengers of the emperor have asked for a miracle or [they will] show us the door. If you command, we will show them a miracle”. But Śrījī did not reply. Then Govindjī became very worried and pondered “Without Śrījī’s command no miracles can be performed, so we will not show any. Now we cannot stay, so now where to find help?”. (ŚNPV 72, pp. 49–50)

In a dream, his deceased elder brother, Giridhārjī, appears to explain the circumstances and to allay Govindjī’s worries:

“This is Śrījī’s will: He will play here in secret. When Śrī Ācāryajī [Vallabha] drew Śrījī’s horoscope and gave him the name Śrī Gopāl, he did that so he would set off to protect the cows. This *mleccha* is just an excuse; in fact the true reason is fulfillment of prior wishes of Vaishnavas. Śrījī will go wherever their wishes are to be made true. So prepare the cart. Tomorrow is the thirteenth of the month, the Sarvasiddhā feast, and when an hour of the day is left Śrījī will triumph. So there’s

⁴⁵Bachrach witnessed a Vallabhan youth performance of this scene in Ahmedabad, which was intended to be humorous. The youth playing the part of Aurangzeb’s character wore a massively oversized costume beard. Accordingly, the emperor became an object of ridicule, pathetic rather than threatening.

⁴⁶This point emerged in discussion at the presentation of this paper at Columbia University on 29 September 2012.

no need to show any miracles. Do as he wishes. Wherever he wishes to stay, go accordingly". (ŚNPV 74, p. 51)

And it is done so accordingly. Thus, it is explicitly stated that the persecution by the *mleccha* is just a pretext. The real reason for Śrī Nāthajī's flight is to oblige his devotees. True to form, before he can leave, Śrī Nāthajī wishes to be scolded by his beloved Brajvasis, who promptly oblige and send him off with an insult: "Will you go or not? Will you have the heads of everyone here cut off, like a coward, or what?" (ŚNPV 75, p. 52). This intimate joking provokes Śrī Nāthajī to smile, and, thus, in high spirits the party leaves for Agra. The direction of the journey in itself seems to confirm the argument that Śrī Nāthajī is not really persecuted, as the imperial capital is hardly the place to visit by someone wanting to flee the emperor.

There are several factors at work in the relating of this incident. For one, the narrative reworks the hagiographical trope of the emperor demanding miracles while the *bhakta* refuses to sell his God so cheaply: miracles come from God's grace and are not meant to become a show for imperial pleasure.⁴⁷ Yet, counter to most versions of this trope, which stress hardships endured by the saint and his eventual triumph, this narrator fails to take the persecution motif seriously. Rather he uses a dream vision of the authoritative deceased *tilakāyat* Giridhārījī to say that Śrī Nāthajī is using the emperor's persecution as an excuse: the real reason for the move is that the deity is obliging his devotees. Attentive listeners to the text can fill in who the devotees may be. From the flashback quoted above we have already learned how the desires of Ajab Kuṇṇvarī of Mewar may have set these workings in motion. The contrast is remarkable: Śrī Nāthajī has free agency with regard to the Mughal emperor, but at the same time with regards to his *bhaktas* the deity is under obligation.

The Battle on the Temple Site

The hagiographical trope of antagonism with the Mughal ruler compulsively plays out as usual. The emperor sends his troops to the temple with the aim to destroy it, but they are miraculously defeated by two water carriers (*jalaghariyā*), who together vanquish 200 *mlecchas*. Over the following six months, they endure no less than seventeen attacks, in the course of which they kill 500 to 700 *mlecchas*. At this point, Śrī Nāthajī sees fit to interfere from Agra, where he is now located. He appears to the water carriers in a vision:

Śrī Giridhārījī has filled you with such zeal that you have killed all these *mlecchas*. But that is not my wish. For now, I will go wherever *bhaktas* have previously received my promise. After fulfilling the wish of those *bhaktas*, in the course of time, I will return to Braj, when all work will be completed. You can just join my *līlā*, do not wage war. (ŚNPV 76, p. 53)

After that, the brothers have a vision of the Mount Govardhana and see a mosque and a *mleccha* sweeping Śrī Nāthajī's temple with his beard. They finally understand what is really going on and give up their weapons to enter the divine *līlā*. When the imperial troops arrive

⁴⁷ See P. Burchett, "Bitten by the Snake: *Yōgīs*, *Tāntra*, and *Mantra* in the Poetry of the *Bhakti* Saints", *Journal of Hindu Studies*, 6.1 (2013), pp. 1–20.

for the eighteenth attack, they do not see any temple, and they build a mosque. All this, by *Vārā* logic, was according to Śrī Nāthajī's divine plan!

Sectarian logic has it both ways in this text: it manages to stress the resistance of the devotees facing the Mughal army, yet Śrī Nāthajī is also distanced from this violence and from defeat. Indeed, he discourages his devotees from fighting back and killing any more *mlecchas*. Eventually, no temple is destroyed; it is miraculously made to disappear. Thus, an answer to the emperor's original challenge emerges: we see a miracle after all.

The concluding assertion that a mosque was built on the site of the Govardhana temple is baffling since there is no record of such an event. This may indicate that the author had no first-hand knowledge of the Govardhana site and conflated it with Mathura. Or it may simply be a case of getting carried away by the compelling logic of the trope of persecution that has to run its course. The numbers of attacks tellingly corresponds with that of the mythical attacks on Krishna's Mathura.⁴⁸ In addition, it may betray something of the late nineteenth-century origin of our text, when the historical interpretation that temples were destroyed, and mosques built, by Aurangzeb had already become a cliché to the extent that even sites where this did not happen were portrayed as such.

Overall, profound ambiguity pervades the hagiographical account of why Śrī Nāthajī left Govardhana. In the first place, the text itself does not mention Aurangzeb by name, though the editors indicate emphatically that he is understood to be the *mleccha*-villain.⁴⁹ But how villainous is Aurangzeb really? He is made out to be a secret devotee of Śrī Nāthajī, driven by the desire to have *darśana* and fulfill God's wishes. Whereas Aurangzeb is commonly understood today as the agent of the persecution that led to Śrī Nāthajī's flight, sectarian understanding emphasises that he is just a puppet in Śrī Nāthajī's hands.

Consequent Persecution

Distancing Aurangzeb from the Action: The Mullā's Persecution

Meanwhile in Agra, Śrī Nāthajī appears in the emperor's dream. He triumphantly declares he is in town, and that the emperor cannot do a thing about it. In the process, he gives him a kick with his feet, as a consequence of which the emperor is said to have a lotus mark on his back. The emperor never tells anyone about this incident, but secretly worships Śrī Nāthajī (ŚNPV 77, pp. 54–55). Aurangzeb's sober diet and ascetic sleeping habits are ascribed to his *tapasyā* to obtain a vision of Śrī Nāthajī!

Officially, Aurangzeb does not get word of Śrī Nāthajī's presence in Agra until after the deity has celebrated the festival of Annakūṭ there with his entourage. When informed by his intelligence officers, however, the emperor admits that he knew all along:

I knew from the day he arrived in Agra, but am I his enemy? I just did as he ordered me to do. Now he can wreak havoc wherever his whim takes him. Do not repeat this in front of anyone else. If the *mullā* hears, he will go after [him]. (ŚNPV 82, p. 59)

⁴⁸F. Smith, "Dark Matter", p. 46 n. 27.

⁴⁹Bachrach's survey of the manuscripts as well as field research in the contemporary community shows that similarly in both cases this meta-text is absent.

Indeed, the *mullā* does get wind of Śrī Nāthajī's whereabouts and immediately sets off in hot pursuit, disregarding Aurangzeb's advice not to do so. But through magic the imperial army is scared off at the Chambal River, and the *mullā* has to abandon the chase (ŚNPV 83, pp. 59–61). In this way, the sectarian account avoids casting this incident as simply a persecution by the emperor. Rather, a *mullā* is blamed and humiliated. The emperor is shown to have known all along of the deity's plan, and to sympathise with Śrī Nāthajī. Perhaps it is no exaggeration to say that in return the *Vārtā*'s authors felt for Aurangzeb's plight as a fellow devotee.

The Mewar Rana

The story of Śrī Nāthajī's journey continues in a somewhat confused fashion, with many stages. Notwithstanding all the sectarian rhetoric of Śrī Nāthajī's defiance of the emperor, the move seems fraught with danger. The deity is transported in a cart with two members of Vallabha's family on horseback in front of and right behind the cart, fully armed. They also do not tell anyone what is in the cart (ŚNPV, p. 67).⁵⁰ We shall return to some episodes that occur in the course of Śrī Nāthajī's travels later, but suffice it to say here that along the way the deity succeeds in fulfilling the wishes of many devotees. The story neatly alternates such incidents with episodes of persecution, in a nearly regular swing of the pendulum.

Towards the end of the journey, Govindjī asks the Mewar Rana, Raj Singh, whether he would allow Śrī Nāthajī to settle in his kingdom. The Rana turns to his mother for advice:

"The Ṭhākur of Braj, Śrī Nāthajī, has fled the *mleccha*'s attack and wishes to stay here in our country. If you command, then I shall have him settle here. But if the *mleccha* gets wind of this and attacks us, then what is our duty?" The Rani answered: "Listen son, by the good luck of Mīrābāi and Ajab Kumvari, Śrījī himself has come to our country. How fortunate we are! For that reason, have Śrī Nāthajī settle here immediately. Do not delay. If the *mleccha* emperor attacks us, then as a Rajput, you are ready to give your life for our soil. Giving one's life for Śrī Ṭhākurjī is special. Have Śrī Ṭhākurjī quickly settle here". (ŚNPV 98, p. 76)

It is here, in the words of the Mewar royalty that we find for the first time the rhetoric of persecution expressed unambiguously. Concern for the image's safety is clearly articulated in terms of conflict of Rajput *dharma* and *mleccha* attack.

Śrī Nāthajī now enters Mewar, but on the way stops at various places to fulfill old promises, such as the liberation of one *lākh* of ghosts at a lake (ŚNPV 98, pp. 76–78). Eventually, the cart gets stuck in Simhād village, where Śrī Nāthajī says Ajab Kumvarī used to live, and where there are *chatris* of Viṭṭhalnāth's descendants. This is where the deity will be installed formally in a hastily built new temple in February 1672 (1728 VS, Phālgun *badi* 7, see ŚNPV, p. 78).

⁵⁰They were accompanied by a third Gosvāmī, who was responsible for the cooking, with some help of the women (ŚNPV, p. 68).

Aurangzeb's Mewar War from a Sectarian Point of View

Now comes the inevitable (by sectarian logic): attack by the emperor on those who sheltered Śrī Nāthajī. But note Aurangzeb's own words when he hears that Śrī Nāthajī had taken shelter in Mewar:

"I had understood he would stay in my empire. Wherever he will go, the empire is mine up to the borders of the sea. And now he has left my empire and has gone to stay in the Rana's kingdom. For that reason I will go and see the Ranajī". Saying thus, the emperor prepared [to depart] and reached Mewar in a few days. (*ŚNPV* 99, p. 79)

In other words, by this point in the narrative, the emperor is shown not so much to persecute but rather to pursue Śrī Nāthajī. What follows seems to be a hagiographical reworking of Aurangzeb's Mewar campaign of 1679–80. As Cynthia Talbot discusses elsewhere in this special issue, this war was waged mainly to suppress the rebellion staged first by the immediate family of Jasvant Singh of Marwar and their allies after Jasvant Singh's death in 1678. The Rana was supporting the rebels and gave the fugitive faction of the Marwar royal family shelter in Mewar, notwithstanding Aurangzeb's repeated attempts to dissuade him.⁵¹ The *Vārtā* dialogue of the Rana consulting his mother⁵² conspicuously looks like a transposition of what was said with regard to the son of Jasvant Singh onto Śrī Nāthajī.

In order to punish Raj Singh for his support of the fugitive Merwar party Aurangzeb first set troops upon him, but the emperor later personally marched on Mewar, setting out from Ajmer in November 1679. The Rana ordered the population to retire into the hilly tracts, laying waste to the plains, but the imperial army pursued them, killing many and causing severe damage in and around Udaipur and Chittor.⁵³ Aurangzeb himself returned to Ajmer in March 1680, and from there marched on to the Deccan to attend to other business. But the remaining imperial forces that remained stationed in Mewar saw their food supply cut off during the guerilla war that the Rajputs waged against them. The imperial army failed to make progress towards punishing the rebels.⁵⁴

How does the *Vārtā* rework these political events? According to the text, the emperor camps near Raysagar, preparing for a long stay, even having a garden laid out. Śrī Nāthajī "hides" for three days in Batara in the hills, where there is a cave in which a *ṛṣi* is practicing penance. Śrī Nāthajī is presented again as going there to oblige this *bhakta*, who presents him with miraculous gifts and goes to heaven after this *darśana* (*ŚNPV* 100, pp. 79–81). Śrī Nāthajī now turns his attention to Aurangzeb's army and sends swarms of bees from his temple to sow confusion among the army's ranks. In the ensuing confusion, Aurangzeb's

⁵¹See also R. C. Hallissey, *The Rajput Rebellion against Aurangzeb: A Study of the Mughal Empire in Seventeenth-Century India* (Columbia, 1977).

⁵²Incidentally, the mother of Raj Singh was Janade Karmeti, daughter of Raj Singh Rāthaur of Merta (see M. Menaria, *Mahākavi Rānchod Bhaṭṭ prajāṇi Rājaprasasti Mahākāvya* [Udaipur, 1973], p. 13; *Sarga* 5). She is known from an inscription at the tank Janasagar constructed by her son in her name near Udaipur, dated 1677 (1735 VS).

⁵³G. N. Sharma, *Mewar and the Mughal Emperors (1526-1707 A.D.)* (Agra, 1962), pp. 145–151; This is written up in the *Futuhāt-e 'Ālamgirī* fols. 47v–79r; see T. Ahmad's translation, *Ishvardas Nāgar's Futuhāt-i-Ālamgirī* (Delhi, 1978), pp. 118–130.

⁵⁴Sharma, *Mewar*, pp. 151–153.

Begum “Rangi Cangi” gets separated from the emperor. Raj Singh chivalrously brings the lady back to her Lord, after which he is like a brother to her (ŚNPIV 101, pp. 81–83).⁵⁵

You have obliged [*bandagī*] my Begum by being her brother by dharma, so please ask for a boon.
I am very pleased with you. (ŚNPIV 101, p. 83)

In response, Raj Singh simply asks him to leave the country and leave his people in peace. Aurangzeb asks for a favour in return:

Please have a mosque built in my name. Kanhaiyā fled Śrī Girirāj and has arrived in your country.
I have tried in many ways to have him stay in my empire, but he chose to come and dwell in your kingdom. So you can stay under his jurisdiction and, as long as that divinity is in your kingdom,
I am not about to come to Mewar. (ŚNPIV 101, p. 83)

This is a remarkable piece of sectarian logic, where the persecution motif is transformed into a protection motif. The negative side-effect of hosting Śrī Nāthajī — attracting the ire of Aurangzeb, as fearfully expressed in the Rana’s consultation with his mother — is here turned on its head. Śrī Nāthajī is now the protector of the Mewar kingdom. As long as he is there, no harm will come to it. He has brought about the bond between Aurangzeb’s Begum and the Rana, and he is now responsible for Aurangzeb’s retreat and promise of no future meddling. From persecuted victim who brings calamity upon his host, Śrī Nāthajī has turned into a protector of the country, producing victory for the Rana who gave him shelter.

Destruction of Temples and Mosques

How does this story relate to the non-sectarian historical record? Contrary to what some nationalist history books proclaim, scholars have shown that the Mughal-Rajput war was not primarily due to religious tensions. For one thing, there were Hindus fighting in the Mughal army, as is clear from the description in the contemporary Sanskrit *Rājaprasasti*.⁵⁶

⁵⁵The historical model of the chivalrously returned Mughal Begum, may be Aurangzeb’s granddaughter, the daughter of the rebel prince Muhammad Akbar (see below on his rebellion). Upon her father’s defeat she had ‘together with her brother, been sent in safety to a small village with the trusted Brahmin, Durgadas (*Futuhāt-e ‘Ālamgirī* fol. 83v; translation, p. 136). Her name is given as Khujista Bano, but she seems to be the same lady, now named Saif un-Nissa Begum, whom the author of the work, Isardās Nāgar, eventually was involved in restoring to Aurangzeb as part of the reconciliation with Durgadas, many years later, in 1694 (*Futuhāt-e ‘Ālamgirī* fol. 166v–8r; translation, pp. 281–283). According to Isardās, when Aurangzeb heard that Durgadas had arranged for her to study the Qur’ān with a lady from Ajmer during her ‘exile’, he became more softly inclined towards Durgadas. Perhaps the *Vārtā* version is a conflation of Durgadas with Raj Singh and of this later incident of the restoration of Aurangzeb’s granddaughter with the account of ‘the Begum gone astray’ during the confusion of the battles. If that is the case, the *Vārtā* text must have been written after 1694. Note that in *Ma’āsir-e ‘Ālamgirī*, Sāqī Must’ad Khān tells the story differently. He says that when Muhammad Akbar had fled on 16 January 1681, he left his family and children behind (although apparently there are some missing lines. Ch. 24 for the year 1680–1; Fol. 202, see J. N. Sarkar (trans.), *Ma’āsir-i-Ālamgirī: A History of the Emperor Aurangzeb-‘Ālamgirī (reign 1658–1707)* (Calcutta, 1947), p. 125). Three daughters, Safiyyat un-Nissa, Zaliyyat un-Nissa and Najibat un-Nissa as well as his wife Salima Banu Begum and others, were brought before Aurangzeb and sent back to Delhi (*ibid.* fol. 203). Since none of these names fits the lady in Isardās’ story exactly, it is possible that they were other sisters, thus the accounts are perhaps not mutually exclusive. According to Sāqī, reconciliation with the Rana came about half a year later on 14 June 1681 (*ibid.*, fol. 208; translation p. 128). He does not mention the reconciliation with Durgadas in 1694.

⁵⁶Menaria, *Rājaprasasti*, pp. 39–40; *Sarga* 23.

Further, while it is sometimes said that the root cause was the re-imposition of the *jiziyā*, a tax on non-Muslims, in 1679 (1735 VS), this seems to have mattered little.⁵⁷ For instance, just after the re-imposition of the *jiziyā* there is a record of a friendly meeting between Aurangzeb and Raj Singh's delegation, which was under the leadership of Jai Singh—Raj Singh's son (and later successor). Interestingly, this delegation then moved on from Delhi to Mathura and Vrindaban for a pilgrimage.⁵⁸

Some chronicles do mention the destruction of temples by Aurangzeb's army. For instance, in *Ma'āsir-e 'Ālamgirī*, Sāqī Musta'id Khān refers to a batch of Aurangzeb's commanders setting out on 4 January 1680 for Udaipur and demolishing the great temple in front of the Rana's palace there.⁵⁹ According to this chronicle, the temple was fiercely defended by twenty opium-intoxicated Rajputs who came out one by one, and were all killed — though not until they had inflicted considerable loss on the imperial army.⁶⁰ There is a Rajput version of the same story, according to which the Rajputs were not defending the temple but rather the royal gate right opposite it, in order to safeguard the reputation of a bard, Bārhaṭh Narū. As the story goes, this bard was taunted for fleeing Udaipur like everyone else in anticipation of the Mughal army's attack. People mocked him for deserting the royal gate where he had frequently received presents for his services on the occasion of royal weddings.⁶¹ In response, to maintain his dignity, he returned and organised a desperate protection of the royal gate by twenty chosen heroes, using the temple as a shelter from whence to mount the attacks.⁶² It is notable that while the Persian chronicle reports this incident as a fierce Rajput defence of the temple, the local memory is not phrased in religious terms, but instead as a defence of the bard's honor. Sāqī Musta'id Khān mentions more incidents of temple destruction,⁶³ but curiously none of the specifics are found at all in *Futuhāt-e 'Ālamgirī*, which was written by the Brahmin Isardās.⁶⁴ *Rājaprasasti* likewise does not relate temple destruction during the campaign by Aurangzeb's army. On the contrary, *Futuhāt-e 'Ālamgirī* foregrounds a counter-campaign by Bhim Singh, one of Raj Singh's sons, who is said to have marched through Gujarat, in the process destroying one big and thirty small mosques in Ahmadnagar.⁶⁵ *Rājaprasasti* too mentions these raids:

⁵⁷Hallisey, *The Rajput Rebellion*, pp. 84–89.

⁵⁸Menaria, *Rājaprasastih*, p. 233; *Sarga* 22.8–9.

⁵⁹This presumably is the Jagadīśa temple, built by Jagat Singh, which, Joffe has argued, was conspicuously built to rival Mughal construction. See J. Joffe, *Art, Architecture and Politics in Mewar, 1628–1710*, Ph.D. Diss. (University of Minnesota, 2005), pp. 91–94.

⁶⁰The term used is *mācātor* (bed-breaker) explained in a footnote in Sarkar's translation as “a kind of soldier among the Rajputs (very indolent and much addicted to opium, but active and brave when roused)”. See *Ma'āsir-e 'Ālamgirī*, Chapter 23 for the year 1679–80; fol. 186; translation, p. 115.

⁶¹Bards receive traditional presents at the occasion when the groom strikes the *torāṇa* at the gate of the bride's house.

⁶²Śyāmaladās, *Vīr Vinod: Mevād kā Itihās* (Jodhpur, 2007 [1886]), p. 1466, with a Marwari *Gīt Chand* commemorating the occasion quoted in fn. 2.

⁶³According to this chronicler, on 24 January, Aurangzeb personally went to Udaisagar and ordered three temples destroyed; and a few days later, on 29 January, another commander who had been pursuing the Rana brings some of the spoils and reports destroying 122 other temples near Udaipur. See *Ma'āsir-e 'Ālamgirī*, Chapter 23 for the year 1679–80; fol. 188; translation, pp. 116–117.

⁶⁴See the relevant fols. 47v–79r; *Futuhāt-i-Ālamgirī*, pp. 118–130.

⁶⁵*Ibid.*, pp. 130–131; this is also mentioned in another chronicle, *Mirāt-e Aḥmadī* (p. 464), as quoted by Śyāmaladās, *Vīr Vinod*, pp. 1.469.

Brave Bhim Singh had them plunder Ahmadnagar
for two lakh rupees in coins and things.
A big mosque and thirty-one small ones were destroyed,
As heroic Bhim Singh showed his anger at the temple destruction.⁶⁶

The temples for which he is seeking revenge are not specified. Later on, perhaps detailing the same campaign, a Dayal Shah is also said to have plundered many villages (presumably in Mughal-occupied Mewar) and destroyed a mosque in one of them (Dharapuri) before proceeding to plunder Ahmadnagar and to tear down the big mosque there.

Dayal Shah destroyed Khera and Vada,
Plundered (A)vanaheda, grabbing flag and drum.
He destroyed Dharapuri and utterly brought down the mosque,
Razed Ahmadnagar completely in plunder.
He brought down the great mosque in the fight.
Thus the complete survey of the bravery of the Lords and heroes.⁶⁷

This makes for a fascinating ‘counter’ discourse. Inspired by political motivations, Mewari official records use a stronger rhetoric than the sectarian ones. The Vallabhan accounts do not report revenge by destroying mosques. Still, the Vallabhan *Vārtā* presents an interesting refraction of Aurangzeb’s war on Mewar in local religious imagination.

The historical denouement of the conflict is also missing from our sectarian account. The Rajputs resorted to diplomatic stratagem and succeeded in winning over the malcontent prince Muhammad Akbar to their side, instigating him to rebel against his father. He was crowned emperor, but the rebellion failed. Aurangzeb returned from the Deccan and — through wily ways — succeeded in isolating his son, and depriving him of his allies. Thus, Aurangzeb emerged victorious on 26 January 1681.⁶⁸ At this point, Aurangzeb was camped near Rajsagar, which may be what the *Vārtā* recalls in the aforementioned incident.

To the delight of the Mewaris, the struggle between father and son constituted, in effect, an important distraction that moved the action away from Mewar. Meanwhile, Raj Singh had died (November 1680; 1737 VS Kārtik *sudī* 10) and was succeeded by Jai Singh, who concluded peace negotiations. These negotiations, held with Prince Azam, resulted in a *farmān* by Aurangzeb (dated 23 February 1681), in which he agreed to withdraw from Mewar in return for certain *parganas*.⁶⁹

Contextualisation

The official Mughal chroniclers may have cast the events discussed above in terms of *jihād*, yet the Vaishnava accounts do not unanimously provide a straightforward narrative of persecution by Aurangzeb in the guise of a bigoted Muslim. What the chronicles deem ‘religious opposition’ is seen in a different light. In the *Śrī Nāthajī kī Prākāṭya-Vārtā*, there is a fair

⁶⁶See Menaria, *Rājaprasastiḥ*, p. 237; *Sarga* 22.26–9; also quoted in Sharma, *Mewar*, p. 151, is the Braj work *Rāj-vilās* canto 15.

⁶⁷See Menaria, *Rājaprasastiḥ*, pp. 260–261; *Sarga* 24. 25–7.

⁶⁸*Futūḥāt-e ‘Ālamgirī* fol. 80r–3v, translation, pp. 132–136

⁶⁹Sharma, *Mewar* (Agra, 1962), pp. 156–157.

amount of accommodation. The image's flight from the emperor is portrayed as *līlā*, or play. The emperor is not really persecuting the deity, but is pursuing Śrī Nāthajī as a devotee. Śrī Nāthajī is not really fleeing, but rather is travelling and relocating out of his own free will, the only thing that constrains him being the love of his devotees. Thus, under the pretext of flight from the Mughals, Śrī Nāthajī is really out to make good on his promises to devotees by fulfilling their wishes. It is only in the Mewar Rana's discourse that the fear surfaces that sheltering Śrī Nāthajī will prompt an attack by the emperor. The Rana's mother formulates an explicitly religious take on the matter when she says that if a Rajput can die fighting for the soil, he surely can die fighting for God. Still, even the Queen-mother is aware that Śrī Nāthajī's real mission is to please his devotees, as she attributes Śrī Nāthajī's arrival in Mewar to Mīrābāi and Ajab Kumvārī. The initiated know better than to believe the emperor had the power to compel Śrī Nāthajī to move.

Is this narrative a 'strategy of coping', the *sampradāya*'s way of coming to terms with a humiliating history? Can we find a precedent or comparable case elsewhere? What, for instance, about the other Vallabhan images?

Caitanyaite version of the trope

The view that the image's flight is due not to the *mleccha*'s threat, but is really an excuse for obliging his devotees, is a trope we do find in other places — even in accounts from other sects. One example of this trope appears in a Gauḍīya hagiography about its charismatic founder Caitanya (1486–1534). Kṛṣṇadās Kavirāj in his 1615 *Caitanya-caritāmṛta* recounts how Caitanya, during his pilgrimage in Braj, felt such respect for Mount Govardhana that he did not want to tread on it with his feet, and this kept him from going for *darśana* in the hilltop temple. Gopāla (the name the Gauḍīyas used to refer to Śrī Nāthajī) then decides to come down himself. He takes up temporary residence in the village Gathuligram, where Mahāprabhu (Caitanya) more conveniently can take his *darśana*. He does so with the excuse that the Tuṛukdhārīs are coming to attack the village of Govardhana:

For this is the merciful nature of Gopāla. Whatever *bhakta* has a desire to see him, and is anxious to see him but cannot climb Govardhana, on some pretext Gopāla himself descends.⁷⁰

Another example is found later in the same text: when Gauḍīya leader Rūpa Gosvāmī comes to Govardhana, he is too old to climb the mountain. This time, Gopāla comes to Mathura — again ostensibly “for fear of the *mlecchas*”. There the deity gives *darśana* to Rūpa and the whole of his party.⁷¹

Note that the threat is not directly to Śrī Nāthajī nor to his temple, but to the village — something that should not surprise us when we ponder the historical circumstances. The incident with Caitanya is supposed to have taken place ca. 1515, when the temple was not built yet.⁷² At that time, as slightly later, when the Gosvāmīs arrived in Braj, there was significant upheaval and a substantial military presence between Delhi and Agra. In any case,

⁷⁰ *Caitanya-caritāmṛta*, *Madhya Līlā*, 18.36–7.

⁷¹ *Ibid.*

⁷² On the building of the temple, see Vaudeville, “The Govardhan Myth”, pp. 37–38.

we find that the trope that the flight of the image was caused by his love for his devotees is not unique to Aurangzeb's rule, to the *Vārtā*, or to Rajasthan, but is also attested to in Bengal, around a century or so earlier in pre-Mughal times. The *Śrī Nāthajī kī Prākṛṭya-Vārtā* is thus contributing to a broader discourse that transcends regional and sectarian boundaries.⁷³

An Image of his own

A second way to contextualise the story of how Śrī Nāthajī 'fled' Aurangzeb is by comparing it with the circulation histories of other Vallabhan images during the same time period. Just before Śrī Nāthajī left Braj, the Śrī Dvārkaḍhīśajī and Śrī Bālākṛṣṇajī deities, at the time both in the possession of the third house, were also moved away from their original locations. Here too we have a *Vārtā* text, the *Śrī Dvārkaḍhīśa kī Prākṛṭya-Vārtā*, which is attributed to the eighteenth-century head of the third house Śrī Brajbhūṣaṇ Lālji.⁷⁴ But in this case, there is no hint that these images with their caretakers were fleeing Aurangzeb. Rather, at the root of their movement lie squabbles between different Vallabhan factions who are competing for the care of the deities. It is in fact Aurangzeb who ends up mediating between the parties. This is the case when Brajrāy sues Brajbhūṣaṇ, the minor adopted heir of Gīridhārī, for the right to the *sevā* of these images. The case is brought before the Mughal court and Brajrāy loses. He is compelled to sign a deed of release (*Fāriḡh-khatī*) acknowledging that his five-year old nephew's party is the rightful caretaker.⁷⁵ However, Brajrāy does not give up and creates a disturbance in the temple that enables him to 'kidnap' the image Śrī Dvārkaḍhīśajī. Eventually, Brajrāy is forced to return the deity to its lawful caretakers, and the image is reinstalled in 1663 (1720 VS Āṣāḥ *sudī* 5). However, Brajbhūṣaṇ's party does not trust Brajrāy and decides it will be safer to move Śrī Dvārkaḍhīśajī away to Ahmedabad. Brajrāy meanwhile manages to ingratiate himself with Aurangzeb and obtains a *farmān* to the effect that he is the rightful caretaker of the small-sized image Śrī Bālākṛṣṇajī. Armed with this document, Brajrāy seeks the military support of the Ahmedabad governor Mahabat Ḳhan, and in 1670 manages to take possession of the image as it was being swung in its cradle. He installs it in Surat, where it still resides today.⁷⁶ Śrī Dvārkaḍhīśajī is moved to Mewar, where he is installed in Kankroli in 1670 (1727 VS Bhādon *sudī* 7), just before the arrival of Śrī Nāthajī.⁷⁷

Śrī Nāthajī's caretakers also had a run-in with the same Brajrāy, who, while on his way to Ahmedabad with Mughal escort, overtook Śrī Nāthajī's party and managed temporarily to wrest control of the image (*ŚNPV* 88–90, pp. 63–5). Sectarian logic regards this as the

⁷³For older examples of the trope of travelling 'deities', we can also turn to the South during the Sultanate, where the travails of the deity Śrī Raṅganātha after capture are portrayed as a 'pilgrimage tour'. R. H. Davis, *Lives of Indian Images* (Princeton, 1997), pp. 127–132. There is a mythological component to this trope, as of course in the scriptures Krishna himself flees Mathura from the approaching Yavanas, to end up in Dwarka (*Ibid.*, p. 130 on the basis of *Viṣṇu-Purāṇa* 5.23).

⁷⁴This text is based on a manuscript of the Kankroli Sarasvatī Bhaṇḍār (119/4) written by the paṇḍyā of the son of the author, Govardhan Tulārām who moved from Nathdwara to Kankroli. The editor reports also that preserved in the same library are two manuscripts written by the grandson of the author (ms. 119/ 5 and 13), as well as yet more modern texts. See V. B. Śarmā, *Śrī Dvārkaḍhīśa kī Prākṛṭya-Vārtā* (Kankroli, 1956), Introduction, p. 4.

⁷⁵This document is reproduced in K.V. Śāstrī, *Kāṅkroli kī Itihās* (Kankroli, 1956), p. 135.

⁷⁶All this in the fifteenth *Ullās* (*Ibid.*, pp. 60–64).

⁷⁷In the sixteenth *Ullās* (*Ibid.*, pp. 65–68).

outcome of an old promise by Śrī Nāthajī to one of Harirāy's ancestors. Brajrāy is granted *sevā* for 28 days—from the month of Māgh to Pauṣ in 1669 (1726 VS). The then rightful *tilakāyat*, Dāūjī, was also still a minor at the time, as his father Giridhārī had been murdered,⁷⁸ and it was his uncle, Govindjī, who was actually in control. When Brajrāy took over *sevā*, Govindjī fled, and in his separation, or *viraha* at being away from the image, started to dress like a yogī. It is disguised as a yogī that Govindjī returned to assess matters. He managed to sneak into the temple and confront Brajrāy in the middle of the latter's *sevā*, threatening to kill him with a dagger. Thinking the better of it, Brajrāy handed over Śrī Nāthajī to his rightful caretakers, and, as we know, went on his way to Ahmedabad, where finally he came into possession of an image of his own.

In sum, we find that the contemporaneous relocation of at least two other Vallabhan major images was not due to persecution by the Mughal emperor Aurangzeb, but rather that the emperor mediated in a conflict between two of Vallabha's descendants.⁷⁹ The hagiographies freely tell these stories. In the final incident involving Brajrāy and Śrī Nāthajī, as told in *Śrī Nāthajī kī Prākṛtya-Vārtā*, we may detect a hint that perhaps the *sevā* of Śrī Nāthajī himself was also under dispute at this time due to the minority of the official caretaker, and that conflicts arising from this dispute may have had to do with the relocation of the image away from Braj.

Śrī Nāthajī in Rupnagar

The final contextualisation for Śrī Nāthajī's itinerancy is the story of an image that came to be established in the kingdom of Kishangarh in the mid-seventeenth century, well before the exodus of the Braj images to Rajasthan began. The image was at the time known as Śrī Govardhdhananāthajī (now known as Śrī Kalyāṇarāyajī). The king who brought it was Rup Singh (r. 1643–48), the fifth ruler of Kishangarh state, who was a general in the Mughal army, battling in Balkh and Qandahar for Shah Jahan. In 1647 Rup Singh founded a new capital, Rupnagar, named after himself. The source that tells of the establishment of the image in Rajasthan is the Kishangarhi court poet Vrind's *Rūp-vacanikā*, which was composed ca. 1715. Vrind first describes the battle of Balkh in which Rup Singh participated in the year 1702 VS (1646 CE).⁸⁰ He continues in laconic bardic rhyming prose:

In the world he obstructed his enemies, meeting them metal for metal. His heart was patient through battle after battle. Summons issued from the emperor. Filled with manhood, he paid obeisance. The emperor received him very kindly, gave him a *mansab*, let him return to his land.

⁷⁸See Ambalal, *Krishna as Shrinathji*, p. 62.

⁷⁹We could add the example of Śrī Viṭṭhalanāthajī of the second house, who was brought to Kotah apparently as early as 1581, later he was moved from there by Harirāy, the author of the *Vārtā*, to Khamnor (Khimnaur) in 1662; yet later he joined Śrī Nāthajī in Nathdwara (*Ibid.*, p. 55). Also Śrī Madanamohanajī of the seventh house was stolen at some point and then seems to have left Braj for Sindh, only to surface later in Nathdwara (*Ibid.* p. 59). All total this amounts to four of the nine major images having been removed from Braj for other reasons than Aurangzeb's 'iconoclasm'. However more careful research on the primary sources is needed. Slightly different is the history of Mukundarāyajī who ended up in Benares thanks to the machinations of a charismatic guru, see V. Dalmia, *The Establishment of the Sixth Gaddī* (New Delhi, 1994).

⁸⁰J. R. Celer, *Vṛnd Granthāvalī* (Agra, 1971), pp. 135–137. For the battles, see E. J. Rapson, W. Haig and R. Burn, *Cambridge History of India* (Cambridge, 1987), p. 203.

He came by way of Braj, visited the temple of Śrī Nāthajī. So pleased he was, joy filled his heart.⁸¹

He elaborates in two *Dohās*:

In the year 1704 VS [1647 CE], he arrived in the Braj area.
With unwavering heart he became steeped in the highest bliss of God's Name.
The guru instructed him in the formula of the immaculate name of God
Devotion was born like a flame, with a full surge of love.⁸²

The bard, however, does not provide any specific information about the guru. Kishangarhi tradition sees him as Vallabhan, identifying him as a grandson of Viṭṭhalnāth, a son of the latter's eldest son Girdharjī by the name of Gopīnāth Dīkṣit (Ambalal 1987: 63). The name of the image that he received is now understood to be Śrī Kalyāṇarājī. However, as we will see, the bard calls the deity Śrī Nāthajī. To continue our reading through the *Vācanikā*, Rup Singh's nascent devotion is celebrated and his vision elaborated:

He received a vision and a command in a joy-drenched dream:
"Please take Śrī Nāthajī to Rupnagar and install him there".⁸³

Next follows a description of the transformation of Rupnagar into surroundings fit for a Krishna *svarūpa* — that is, a Braj-like cowherd paradise, which is then underlined to be a year-round transformation of the urban landscape by means of a description of the seasons.⁸⁴ This conversion of the city into a rural paradise over six seasons is mirrored in a ripening of the king's devotion by following the nine-step programme of *bhakti*.⁸⁵ Finally, the bard concludes:

Such was he accomplished in nine-fold devotion. He immersed his heart in Śrī Nāthajū. He listened to beautiful recitation: of *Bhāgavata-purāṇa* and *Bhāgavad-gītā*, listened to the *Bhārata*. He obtained that way harmony in worldly and spiritual goals [*svārtha* and *paramārtha*]. Follower of the Vaishnava path, benefactor of devotees, great patron, like an incarnation of Ambarīṣa, he embodied the whole earth, this incomparable king, His Highness Rup.⁸⁶

And with that, the devotional interlude is over and the king goes off to his next campaign in Qandahar, here dated 1706 VS (1749 CE). Later on, we also see him fight the Rana of Mewar and destroy the fort of Chittor.⁸⁷ In short, the devotional interlude is firmly sandwiched

⁸¹ *Ibid.*, *Kavita* 143, p. 137.

⁸² *Ibid.*, *Dohā* 144–145, p. 137.

⁸³ *Ibid.*, *Dohā* 147, p. 138.

⁸⁴ *Ibid.*, 148–151, pp. 138–139.

⁸⁵ *Ibid.*, 152–162, pp. 139–143.

⁸⁶ *Ibid.*, prose passage, p. 143.

⁸⁷ *Ibid.*, 185–200, pp. 147–150. The Mewar kings also were ardent Krishna devotees and may have preceded Rup Singh in their association with the Vallabhans, as Maharana Jagat Singh I (r. 1628–52) is said to have been 'converted' by a Gosvāmī of the third *gaddī*, which is backed up by a land grant, see S. Saha, "The Movement of *Bhakti* along a North-West Axis: Tracing the History of the Puṣṭimārg between the Sixteenth and Nineteenth Centuries", *International Journal of Hindu Studies* 11.3 (2007), p. 309. This did not immediately entail an import of images though: as we have seen, the image of Śrī Nāthajī (of the first house) was not installed until the reign of Jagat Singh's son Raj Singh I (r. 1653–80). Also, the third *gaddī's* *nidhisvarūpa*, Śrī Dvārkanāthajī, when it left Gokul went

between two campaigns in the service of the Mughals.⁸⁸ The acquisition of the Vallabhan image for Rupnagar occurs on the way home from Delhi after a campaign in Afghanistan. Thus, no conflict is felt here between service to the Mughals on the one hand and to Krishna deities on the other.

Significantly, this political appropriation of the Vallabhan image for a new capital predates the installation of the now more famous Śrī Nāthajī image in Nathdwara by nearly a quarter of a century. While the latter is often in popular imagination said to have ‘fled’ Aurangzeb’s iconoclastic zeal, the former image’s move to Rajasthan takes place rather emphatically in the midst of Rajput-Mughal cooperation.

A mid-nineteenth-century chronicle recounts a similar trajectory during the early eighteenth century with regard to another Vallabhan image, Śrī Brajanāthajī, which was brought to Kotah. There is a twist in this story, though: Kotah’s king, Bhim Singh I (r. 1707–1720) had gone to Delhi to congratulate the new emperor Muhammad Shah and on this auspicious occasion was offered a gift. Bhim Singh asked to be confirmed in whatever land he would conquer by the sword. Having secured the emperor’s blessing, he went to Braj, was initiated in the Vallabha-Sampradāya, and obtained the tutelary image of Śrī Brajanāthajī (called in the text Śrī Nāthajī). He too ‘transformed’ his capital into Krishna’s world, by renaming it after Krishna’s parental village Nandagaon. However, this all seems to have been part of an elaborate ruse. Immediately after his initiation, the king is said to have staged his own cremation to lure the neighbouring ruler of Bundi into his kingdom. All this so that he could then come back “as a ghost” to drive out the Bundi king, pursue him to his own capital, and plunder the treasury. In short, Bhim Singh conquered new lands in which the emperor was now obliged to confirm him. He continued to invade more territories, with Śrī Brajanāthajī prominently placed at the head of his army.⁸⁹

Here we find that there is nothing new about Krishna images moving out of Braj to grace royal capitals and help shore up Rajput kings’ rule. The first example is from the 1640s, to grace Rupnagar while Shah Jahan was emperor; the second is from 1720, to grace Kotah while Muhammad Shah was on the Delhi throne. In the second case the image went on to ensure victory for its patron. We have found at least two examples where the acquisition of such an image follows immediately upon a trip to Delhi confirming the Rajput king’s loyalty to the Mughal emperor. This suggests that the proximity of Braj to the imperial capital may have played a role in its popularity as a pilgrimage centre for vassals of the Mughals. The gurus of Braj were only too happy to oblige and provide the kings with their images, and undoubtedly the benefit was mutual: the king as well as the religious dignitaries all won in prestige.

first to Ahmedabad in 1670 and did not come to be installed in Kankroli, where it resided until 1720 (Ambalal, *Krishna as Shrinathji*, p. 57).

⁸⁸Worship of the goddess too is mentioned in this way, thus a description of Vijai Daśamī in 1712 VS (after his military victory; Celer, *Vṛnd Granthāvalī*, 222–226, pp. 155–156) where he also distributes salaries to his soldiers and compensation to the wounded and bereft.

⁸⁹N. Peabody, “In Whose Turban Does the Lord Reside? The Objectification of Charisma and the Fetishism of Objects in the Hindu Kingdom of Kota”, *Comparative Studies in Society and History*, 33.4 (Oct., 1991), pp. 735–737, 743.

Conclusion

We have shown that yet another of the grand narratives of religious/ideological clashes in South Asia stands in need of qualification. The so-called exodus of Braj images was perhaps not in all cases due to Aurangzeb's iconoclasm. First, the sectarian narratives themselves do not assert that all the images that left Braj did so in the face of persecution. In several cases the move is squarely blamed on intra-sectarian rivalry, and the emperor is actually said to have mediated conflicts between different contenders.

In those cases where persecution is mentioned, the hagiographers' sectarian discourse does not completely dovetail with the twentieth-century narrative of communal conflict either. Norbert Peabody has advocated a multi-agentive view of history.⁹⁰ Rather than singling out Aurangzeb as the driving force, our analysis reveals multiple agents: the caretakers of the deities, the patrons and their rivals, the *bhaktas* of the past and present with their wishes, the enemy-*bhakta*, and, of course, the deities themselves. Gavin Flood has noticed as typical for the movement of objects that he has studied a "dialectic between alterity and identity, continuity and change, confrontation and cooption".⁹¹ We may broadly postulate that the Braj sectarian images were similarly moved in response to multiple challenges to established loyalties and allegiances, in order to accommodate and respond to changing circumstances, such as insecurity due to local uprisings and threats by rivals striving to appropriate images. The analysis of the sectarian rhetoric of the *Śrī Nāthajī kī Prākāṣya-Vārtā*, which justifies the peregrinations of Śrī Nāthajī in particular, demonstrates how narrative strategies were used to negotiate the remembrance of a difficult situation in a non-confrontational way. This is not to deny that there was, among others, a factor of threat perceived as a challenge from Islamic orthodoxy. Nor even do we wish to go as far as to emphasise economic factors as the main reason for the movement of the images, as some have suggested.⁹² Rather, our sources show that narratives claiming the fear of iconoclasm as the single reason for the movement of deities must be nuanced.

Within the Vallabha-Sampradāya itself, the *Śrīnāthjī kī Prākāṣya-Vārtā* remains alive in contemporary performances. The narrative presents Śrī Nāthajī's *alaukika* dalliances, his *līlā*, as other-worldly, even 'secret'. Perhaps due to this esoteric approach, the more 'normative' public discourse on the topic of Hindu-Mughal relations continues to remain largely unchallenged in the *sampradāya*. Careful attention to the narratives of Vallabhan devotional texts themselves, as they are still alive today, may yet help to balance the standard accounts. Such attention to these texts will also help scholars gain further understanding of how the logic of Śrī Nāthajī's *līlā* has influenced the Vallabha-Sampradāya's own recounting of the past.

Ironically, contemporary communal discourse derives from the Mughal chronicles' views rather than early accounts from the images' communities. Vernacular sectarian sources show that while the images may on occasion have been 'victims' of tumultuous times — due to multiple villains both within and outside the *sampradāya* — in the understanding of

⁹⁰Peabody, *Hindu Kingship*, p. 170.

⁹¹Flood, *Objects of Translation*, p. 4.

⁹²E. A. Richardson, "Mughal and Rajput Patronage of the bhakti Sect of the Maharajas, The Vallabha Sampradaya, 1640-1760 A.D.", Ph.D. Diss. (University of Arizona, 1979), pp. 60-70.

their caretakers they were not ‘victims’ but ‘victors’, bringing prosperity to their hosts.
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